ZARA GAME

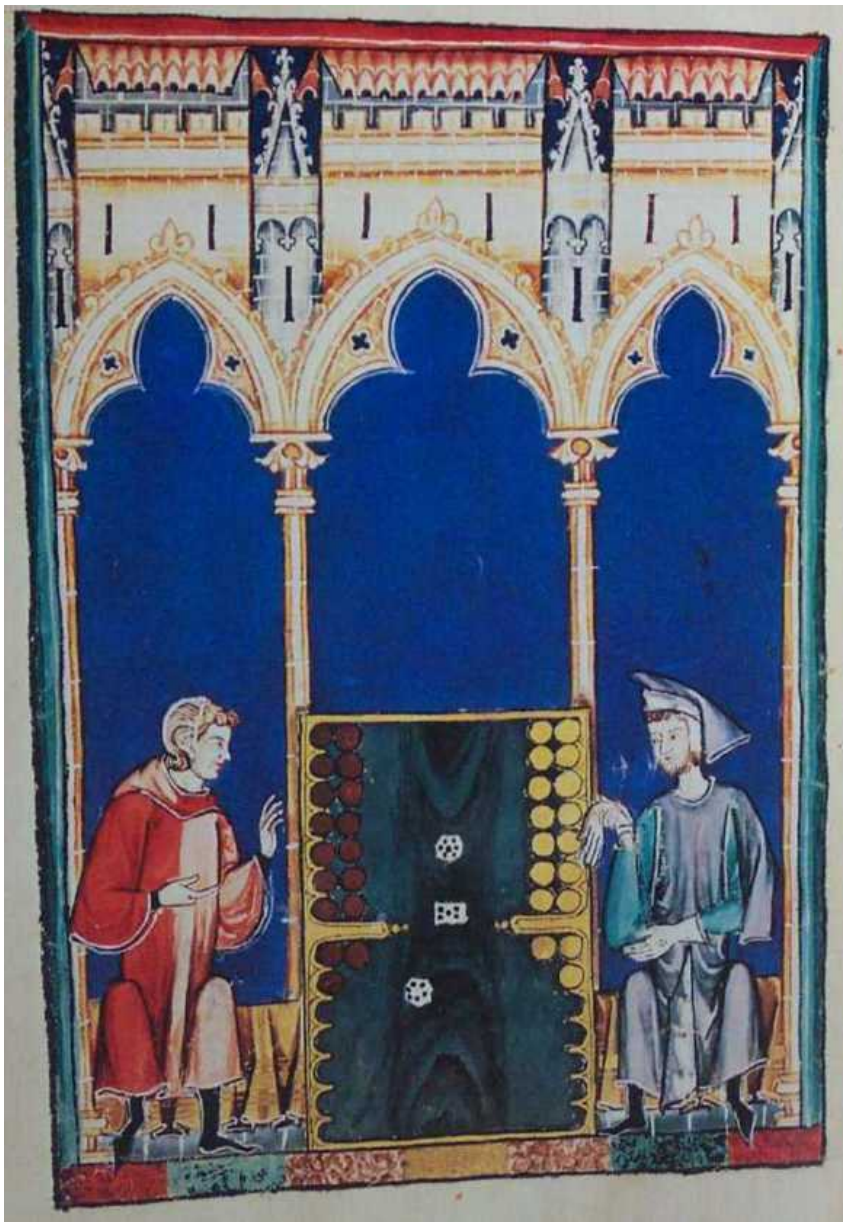


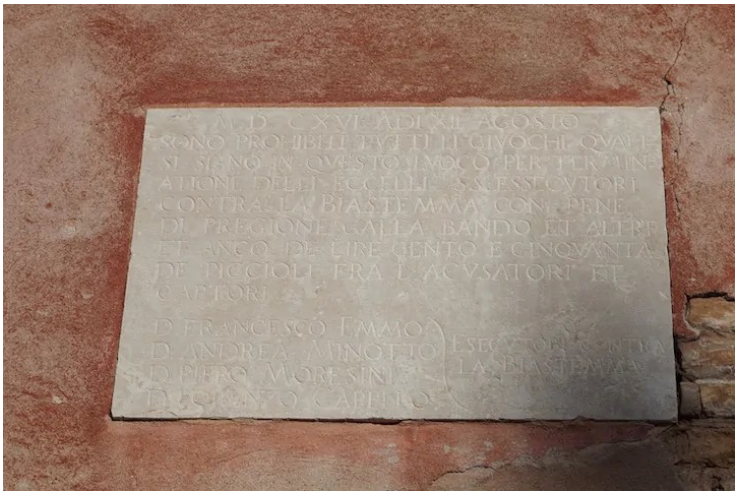
Illustration from "El libro de los juegos" – Seville (Spain) 1280
Original preserved in the Royal Library of the Monasterio de San Lorenzo de El Escorial

The Zara Game wasn't just a gambling pastime: it represented a social and cultural phenomenon that spanned centuries and very different social classes. It spread throughout Europe between the 13th and 16th centuries, and was played everywhere—from taverns and crowded squares to aristocratic palaces and royal courts—always with the same allure: entrusting one's fate to the roll of the dice. Playing Zara meant sharing a common language, made of luck, risk, and hope, which reflected the medieval mentality, where chance and divine providence were intertwined.

The name *zara* derives from the Arabic *az-zahr* ("dice, luck"), confirming the close connection between gambling and destiny. For medieval man, dice were not simply objects of chance, but instruments through which fate and divine will manifested themselves. Each roll represented the intersection of human freedom and the mystery of fate.

In medieval Europe, marked by the influence of the Church of Rome, random games were considered dangerous and morally reprehensible. The main reason was that such games were based on the invocation of **Fortune**, a figure inherited from classical culture and depicted as a blindfolded and unstable goddess. The idea of relying on the whims of a pagan goddess was difficult to reconcile with the Christian vision, in which human life was guided by **divine Providence** and not by chance.

For this reason, the Game of Zara and dice games in general were the subject of numerous ecclesiastical condemnations: preachers and bishops accused them of fomenting vice, wasting time, and economic ruin. Many municipal statutes, inspired by these warnings, even prohibited their practice with fines or corporal punishment.



Decree against gambling, Facade of the Church of San Giacomo dell'Orio, Venice

Yet, despite bans and excommunications, zara remained immensely popular. Its allure stemmed precisely from its connection to destiny: a lucky throw could change the course of an evening, a fortune, or even an entire life. Thus, while the Church denounced it as an instrument of perdition, for players, zara continued to embody hope and challenge, an opportunity to win Fortune's favor.

The game's popularity is confirmed by medieval literary sources. **Dante Alighieri**, for example, opens Canto VI of the Inferno with a simile comparing damned souls to zara players:

> *Qual è colui che a la zara è vinto,*
> *che 'n trista gente si rimane e pensa,*
> *rivolendo colui che ha vinto, lieto…*
>
> *As he who is defeated at the stake,*
> *who remains among sad people and thinks,*
> *wanting the one he has conquered back, happy…*

(*Inferno*, VI, 1-3)

The comparison was immediately clear to the medieval reader: the contrast between the euphoria of the winner and the desolation of the losers was a common tavern scene.

Francesco Petrarca, in *De remediis utriusque fortunae*, condemns gambling as a vain waste of time and money:

> *Quid aliud est alea quam insanorum ludus, temporis et pecuniae iactura?*

(What is the risk of unhealthy ludus, temporis and pecuniae iactura?)

Giovanni Boccaccio, in the *Decameron* (day 8, story 2), cites Zara as an example of deception and misfortune, telling of those who, driven by the desire to win, ended up losing everything:

> *…a zara e a tavole assai volte perduto avea quello che a guadagnare pensava…*

(…at zara and at tables he had often lost what he had hoped to gain…)

These quotes demonstrate how the zara was deeply rooted in the imagination of the time, becoming an emblem of the fragility of fortune and the precariousness of worldly goods.

The zara united and divided at the same time. In taverns, it was an opportunity for socializing, but often also for arguments and brawls; in noble courts, it became an elegant pastime, accompanied by high stakes that could change the fate of entire fortunes. In both cases, the game represented a microcosm of medieval society, where fate and fortune seemed to govern the lives of both the humble and the powerful, leaving profound traces in the Italian language that still testify to the game's profound influence today.

Numerous Italian expressions have medieval origins, deriving from the practice of the game. Some of these derive from the *Zara game*, such as the phonetic assonance of the term "zara," which over time

became "zero." Other expressions still widely used in Italy today are those related to luck, such as "let it be the right time" or "this is the right time that...", which reflect the desire for a new attempt to yield the desired outcome, like the roll of dice in the game called "time." Similarly, the expressions "buona sorte" (Good luck) and "cattiva sorte" (bad luck) derive from Spanish, where the term "sorte" (fate, luck) indicated both fate and the immediate outcome of a game. Last but not least, the Italian word "azzardo" (hazard, chance) itself derives directly from the Arabic az-zahr ("dice"). From a simple reference to gambling, the term later broadened to mean risk and an uncertain undertaking. Today, it retains this dual meaning: playful (a game of chance) and figurative (a risky, reckless act).

Thus, even though the Gioco della Zara has disappeared, its legacy lives on in the words and expressions we use to talk about risk, luck, and hope.

PURPOSE OF THE GAME

The aim of the game is to guess the number that will come up from the roll of the dice to win the stake.

GAME RULES

The rules illustrated here are those of the original Italian version from 1300. Other European variations will be discussed in the "Game Variants" section. In this game, as with almost all medieval dice games of chance, there was no limit on the number of players.

The classic Italian rules of the Game of Zara include the following phases:

1. The players agree on a stake and place it on the bank;
2. The first player is determined (by agreement, by rolling the dice, etc.).
3. In turn, each player calls, that is, declares the number they are betting on, between 3 and 18 (the minimum and maximum score achievable with three dice).
4. After the call in step 3), the dice are rolled:
    a. If the called number is rolled, the player wins and collects, so the game starts again from step 1.
    b. If the number rolled is different from the called number, the other players shout *"zara!"* and the turn passes to the next player.

Note that the numbers 10 and 11 are the most likely: given the same value, the number of possible combinations to obtain these numbers is higher than in other cases.

Sum	**Nr. of combination**	**Probability %**
3 – 18	1/256	0,46%
4 – 17	3/256	1,39%
10 – 11	27/256	12,0%

GAME VARIANTS

One of the most popular variations, especially in Italy, requires the player to pay the stake in case of a loss.

After the call, the player who rolled the die can obtain three outcomes:

- Guess the number rolled: as per the rules, the player wins and collects the stake paid at the beginning of the game;
- Guess the number rolled incorrectly and the number rolled is 3, 4, 17, or 18: the player does not win, the other players shout "zara!" and the turn passes;
- Guess the number rolled incorrectly and the number rolled is not among the "zara" numbers from the previous point: in this case, the player loses and pays the penalty, which is the stake multiplied by the value rolled.

Spanish Variant

The Spanish variant was called Juego de Azar and is described in the manuscript "Libros de los juegos" by Alfonso X "El Sabio." Note that this variant is specifically designed for only two players and a game director who rolls the dice for both.

All players pay the base bet. Each player takes turns calling out the number they expect to roll.

The sums 3–6 and 15–18 are called Azar (rare, extreme).

The sums 7–14 are called Reazar (more common, central).

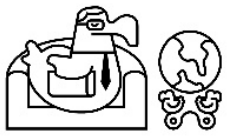
On the first roll: if Azar comes up, the player wins immediately; otherwise, the number rolled becomes the opponent's Suerte, who must then guess this new value to win. However, if any "Azar" number comes up, the player loses.

French Variant

First in France and then in England, this game became widespread among the wealthier classes in the modern era, between the late 18th and early 19th centuries.

This variant, unlike the classic game and the Spanish variant, is played with only two dice.

Players take turns placing their bets on the table, and the first player calls the "main" number, between 5 and 9. If the roll is 2 or 3, the player loses immediately; if the roll is 11 and the "main" number called was 7, the player wins immediately.



THE ADVICE OF THE DODO

Don't mortgage your nest, it's easy to lose it here!